

Golden Gate Bridge

An elegant suspension bridge that spans the strait of water that connects San Francisco Bay with the Pacific Ocean



Until the mid-20th century, San Francisco was the largest US city still served by ferryboats. Access across the Golden Gate—the 1-mile- (1.6-km-) wide strait separating the northern tip of the San Francisco peninsula from Marin County to its north—was by a 20-minute ferry journey that cost \$1 a vehicle.

Overcoming objections

Building a bridge across the strait had often been considered, but it was opposed by the US Department of War, as it could interfere with shipping. The Southern Pacific Railroad, a powerful business in California, also objected, as the bridge would provide competition for its ferry services. It filed a lawsuit against the project, prompting a mass boycott of its ferry services. After much argument, in 1928, the California legislature set up the Golden Gate Bridge and Highway District as the official body to design, construct, and finance the bridge. The Wall Street

Crash of 1929 meant the district was unable to finance the project, but after bonds were raised locally, construction finally began on January 5, 1933.

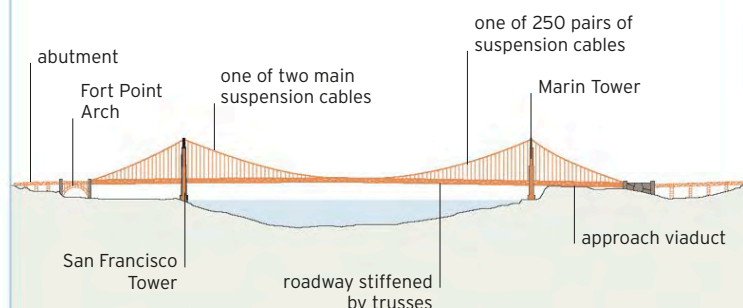
The bridge itself is a simple suspension bridge designed by various structural engineers and architects. In order to cope with the high winds in the strait, the roadway was built to be thin and flexible enough to twist in the wind. The bridge is not golden—“Golden Gate” refers just to the strait below—but is painted in a special color known as international orange, which was originally used as a sealant for the bridge. The US Navy, however, had wanted the bridge to be painted with black and yellow stripes to ensure it was visible to passing ships.

The day before it opened on May 27, 1937, 200,000 local people crossed the bridge on foot and roller skates, but since then its main traffic has been motor vehicles, using both US Route 101 and California State Route 1, which merge to cross the bridge.

The **two towers** of the bridge are held together by **1.2 million steel rivets**

SPANNING THE GOLDEN GATE

The cables holding up the Golden Gate Bridge are held by anchorage blocks inside the two huge abutments on either side of the water. At the time of its opening in 1937, the bridge was both the longest and the tallest suspension bridge in the world, although 14 bridges are now longer and 20 are taller. The two towers each stand 746 ft (227 m) tall and are 4,198 ft (1,280 m) apart. The total length of the bridge from abutment to abutment is 8,981 ft (2,737 m), the roadway clearing the strait below by an average of 220 ft (67 m).



△ SUSPENDED ROADWAYS

Each of the 250 pairs of vertical suspender cables that support the roadway is made of 27,572 strands of galvanized steel wire, their total length estimated to be around 80,000 miles (130,000 km).